

INDIA'S CREATOR ECONOMY

Somewhere between the Instagram Reel you scrolled past at breakfast and the YouTube review that talked you out of a phone purchase last week, India built one of the world's largest creator economies. It now has more monetised creators than most countries have professional journalists, pulls in brand budgets that used to go to TV, and is on track to influence over a trillion dollars in consumer spending by the end of the decade. Here are the five numbers that explain where India's creator economy actually stands right now, and where it's headed.

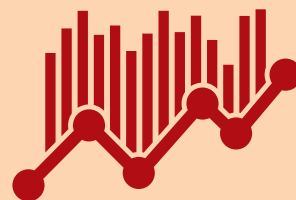
1 It's a big industry

Forget the "side hustle" framing – India's creator economy is a proper industry now. The catch: nobody agrees on the size. KPMG-Redseer's commonly-cited number puts it at roughly \$2.5 billion in 2025, on track to cross \$5 billion by 2027. Boston Consulting Group, looking at a wider lens, says creators are already steering between \$350 and \$400 billion of what Indians actually spend each year – a number BCG expects to cross \$1 trillion by 2030.



2 40 lakh creators and counting

India now has somewhere between 35 and 45 lakh content creators – nearly 3x the count from a few years ago. Cheap data, sub-10,000 smartphones, and a Reels/Shorts-shaped attention economy turned every bedroom into a potential studio. BCG reckons 20–25 lakh of these creators are actually monetised, and they sway 30%+ of consumer purchase decisions – the single biggest reason your "research" before buying anything has shifted from Google to a YouTube review or an Instagram unboxing.



3 Creators are getting brand deals

The EY–Big Bang Social State of Influencer Marketing in India report has the spend math: influencer marketing jumped 25% in 2024 to 2,344 crore and is set to hit 3,375 crore by 2026. Agency trackers like upGrowth peg actual 2025 spend at 3,600+ crore, with projections of 5,500 crore by end of 2026. The interesting bit isn't the total – it's the shape. 3 in 4 brand strategies now bake in influencers, and 47% of brands actively prefer micro and nano creators over the big-ticket names because the cost-per-reach math just works better. The mega-influencer era is quietly giving way to the niche-creator era.



4 YouTube and Meta own the pipes

India is YouTube's biggest market on the planet – about 500 million users, 60.9% of all internet users in the country. In 2024, YouTube alone added \$1.8 billion to India's GDP and supported 930,000 jobs across its creative ecosystem. The bigger story for tech readers is the language stack: over 60% of YouTube India's watch time is now in regional languages, with Tamil, Telugu, and Bhojpuri leading the charge – which is why AI dubbing tools and vernacular keyboards are suddenly hot creator infrastructure. Meta isn't sitting it out either: 1 million+ Indian creators are already monetising via Reels bonuses and brand deals.



5 Bharat and regional content growing

The next 50 crore creator-economy users won't be in Mumbai or Bangalore. 480 million-plus Tier-2 and small-town Indians already watch video online, but only ~35% have ever shopped online. Creators are the bridge – expected to onboard 50–60 million new Bharat shoppers by 2030 and add \$25 billion to e-commerce GMV. The reality check, though: fewer than 10% of Indian creators earn anything meaningful, and discoverability plus payment-rail problems hit hardest in Tier-2/3. India's CPM rates are \$0.60–\$1.40 for local-audience content, against \$32–\$36 in the US – meaning a Hindi creator pulling 10 lakh views can earn less than an English creator pulling 50,000. The pyramid is steep, and most of it is base.

